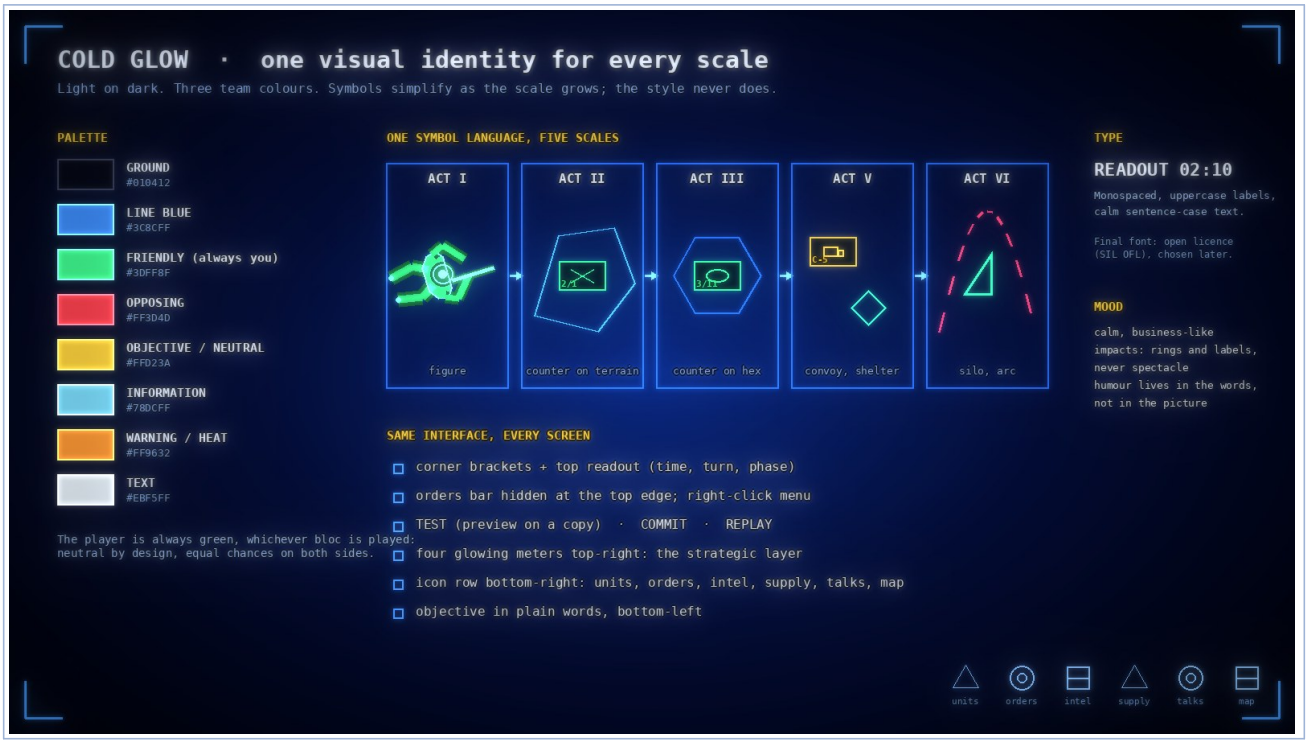
Cold Glow

One visual identity from a spy in a Berlin street to the end of the world. Concept and mock-ups for the new game.

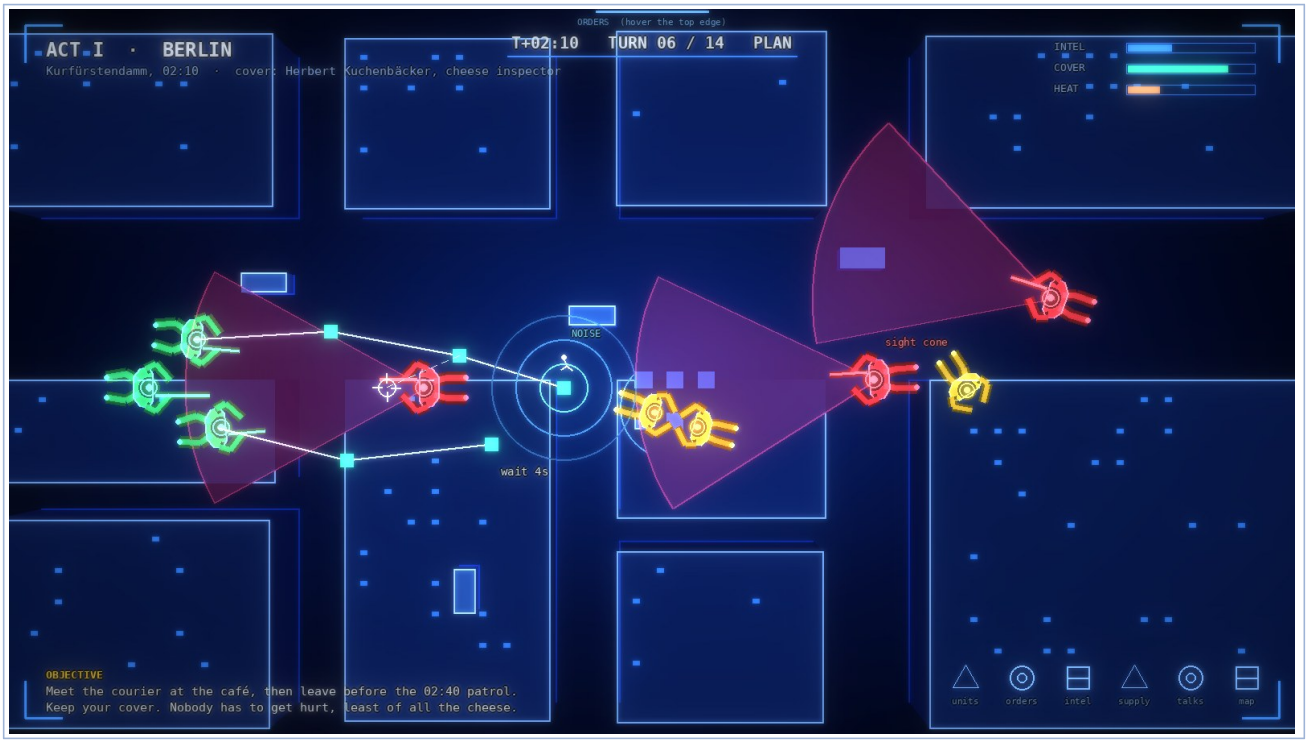
Summary. Your references (Frozen Synapse, Defcon, Grigsby-style maps, Commandos, X-COM) all have strengths, but they look nothing alike, and your priority is recognition: a spy mission and a continental invasion should feel like the same game. My proposal is that Defcon and Frozen Synapse already share the right family trait (light on dark, glowing line-work, information as decoration), so that becomes the identity at every scale. What changes with scale is the *symbol* (figure, counter, hex counter, silo and arc), never the style. The interface frame and the way you give orders stay identical too. The five mock-ups below show the same ingredients at five scales; they were drawn with an image script to show the look, and are not engine footage yet.

The rules of the look

- **Light on dark, always.** Near-black ground with a soft blue glow, no textures, no photo-realism.
- **Three team colours that never change meaning:** green is you, red is the opposing side, yellow is objectives and neutrals. The player is always green, whichever bloc is played, which also keeps the game neutral.
- **Symbols simplify as the scale grows,** at the same line weight: figure, then counter, then hex counter, then silo and arc.
- **One interface frame:** corner brackets, a top readout, four glowing meters for the strategic layer, an icon row bottom-right and the objective in plain words bottom-left.
- **One way to give orders:** the orders bar hidden at the top edge, the right-click menu, TEST, COMMIT and REPLAY, from Act I to Act VII.
- **Information is the decoration:** sight cones, range outlines, supply lines and missile arcs are the scenery.
- **The mood is calm and business-like,** most of all when the stakes are highest. Impacts are rings and labels, not spectacle. The humour lives in the words, never in the picture.



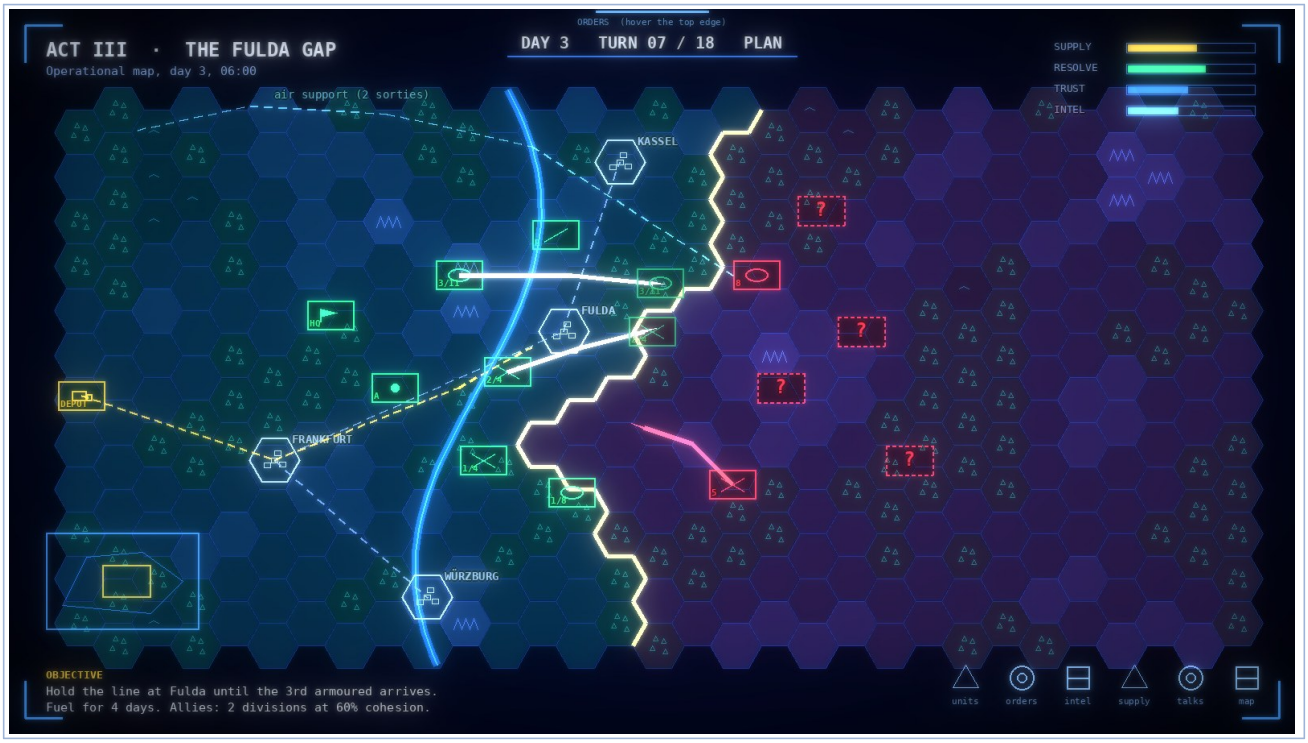
Style sheet. Palette, one symbol language across five scales, the shared interface, type and mood.



Act I, Berlin. The close view, in the same style as the current game: extruded blocks, figures, orders as green squares joined by white lines, a crosshair, a stance icon, a noise ripple, and enemy sight cones. The cover identity is a joke, the stakes are not.



Act II, the border. Terrain by contour lines and tree glyphs, a river, small counters, the movement outline of the selected platoon, an artillery arc with its blast radius, a '?' contact and an observation cone.



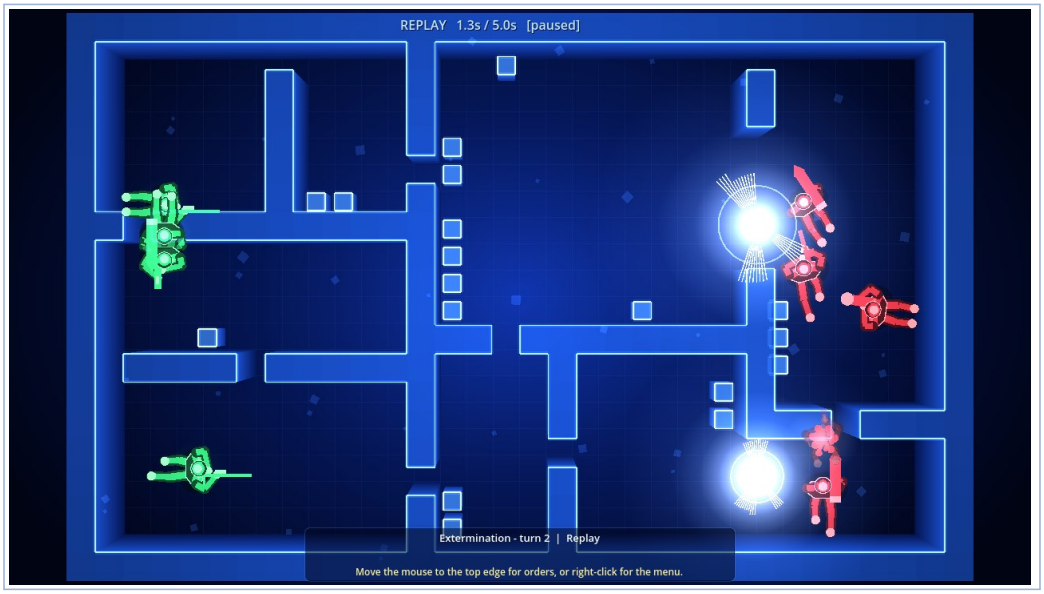
Act III, the Fulda Gap. The operational hex map: terrain by hex, the front line drawn as a glowing edge, supply line, '?' contacts, counters with original symbols and strength numbers, a previewed move (ghost counters), an air support arc, a minimap and the four strategic meters.



Act V, the wasteland. The same map and counters with contamination as glowing hot zones, shelters, convoys and scarcity meters. The frame did not change.



Act VI, the world. A Defcon-like vector world map with silos, subs, radar, missile arcs and rings for impacts, in the same palette, frame and meters. Real coastlines come from public-domain Natural Earth data.



Drill-down view. A real screenshot from the current Cold Synapse build. A decisive operational battle could open in this close view, and the result would flow back to the hex map.

What I would build, and what would need an artist

- **All of this can be drawn in code,** with no art assets, in Godot: the hex map, counters, contours, arcs and glow, the same way the current board is drawn.
- **Zooming between scales:** figures shrink into counters, counters into front lines. The same glow style makes the transition look natural.
- **A painted or isometric look** (like Commandos or X-COM) would be a different identity and would need an artist. For the special-operations missions I suggest keeping the neon style with height levels and view cones.
- **A final font** must be chosen: an open-licence monospace. The placeholder here is DejaVu Sans Mono.

Questions for you

- Does Cold Glow (one neon look at every scale) feel right, or do you want the mid-scale to be more painted?
- Is 'the player is always green' acceptable for both campaigns?
- Anything in these mock-ups you want changed in colour, density or mood?